There is nothing wrong in this, it is only human. What is interesting is that later rulers instinctively understood what the Mauryans were trying to do. As we shall see in the following chapters, they not only created their own edifices but also systematically tried to link themselves to the Mauryans. Moreover, they continued to do this centuries after the Brahmi script had been forgotten and the original edicts could no longer be read. It is remarkable how this chain was deliberately sustained not just by Indian kings but also by rulers of foreign origin. It is as if these kings were conscious that they were just a moment in the history of a very ancient people and they wanted to record their place in it.

One of the best places to experience this is Girnar hill in Junagarh, Gujarat. At the foot of the sacred hill, there is a rock outcrop with an Ashokan edict. More than three centuries later, a Saka (i.e. Scythian) king called Rudradaman added his own inscription next to it. The second inscription records the restoration of the Sudarshana reservoir. We are told that the reservoir was originally constructed by Pushyagupta, Chandragupta Maurya's provincial governor, and that it was completed during Ashoka's time by Tushaspa, an official of possibly Greek origin. The inscription goes on to say that the reservoir was severely damaged by a great storm and floods in the year 72 (probably 150 AD). This was considered a catastrophe by the local people, but Rudradaman proudly tells us that he had the lake restored within a short time and without resorting to forced labour or extra taxes.

This is not the end of the story. Another three hundred years later, the Sudarshana lake burst its banks again. There is a third inscription on the rock that tells us that this time it was repaired by Emperor Skandagupta of the Gupta dynasty in 455-56 AD. If this is not a sense of history, what is?

Girnar is remarkable not just for these inscriptions. It is one of those places where fragments from India's long history sit piled up on top of each other. To experience this, climb up the hillock behind the rock inscriptions and above the picturesque Kali shrine. On one side, you will see Girnar hill with its multitude of ancient Hindu–Jain temples. On the other side is Junagarh fort and town. The fort is one of the oldest in the world and,